

Ginger vs Turmeric for Arthritis: Which Actually Works?

A UK clinician's side-by-side look at ginger and turmeric for arthritis pain — what the evidence shows, sensible doses, safety flags, and how to combine them in everyday food.

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Patients ask me this almost every week: "If I only pick one — should it be ginger or turmeric?" Both are cheap, widely available in UK supermarkets, and both have real anti-inflammatory evidence behind them. But they aren't interchangeable, and neither is a substitute for the treatments your GP or rheumatologist recommends.



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Here is the honest, evidence-based comparison — written for people living with osteoarthritis or inflammatory arthritis in the UK.

What ginger actually does for joint pain

Ginger (*Zingiber officinale*) contains gingerols and shogaols, compounds that dampen the same inflammatory pathways NSAIDs act on — COX-2 and pro-inflammatory cytokines like TNF- α and IL-1 β . That's the mechanism. What about real people?

Meta-analyses of randomised trials in **knee osteoarthritis** show ginger extract produces a modest but real reduction in pain and stiffness compared with placebo, typically over 4–12 weeks. The effect is smaller and less consistent than turmeric, and study quality varies, but ginger clears the "better than nothing" bar that most food-based interventions fail.



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How much ginger, and in what form?

- **Standardised extract:** 500–1,000 mg per day, split into two doses with food.
- **Fresh root:** roughly 1–2 g per day (a thumb-sized piece grated into tea, curry, or a smoothie).
- Give it at least **4–8 weeks** before deciding whether it helps.

Ginger is genuinely food. If you'd rather skip capsules, drinking two cups of strong ginger tea a day is a reasonable starting point.

What turmeric (curcumin) actually does



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Turmeric's active molecule is **curcumin**, and this is where the evidence gets more interesting. Curcumin blocks NF-κB, COX-2, and multiple inflammatory cytokines — mechanistically similar to ginger, but usually with a bigger effect size in trials.

A well-cited 2016 systematic review and meta-analysis concluded that around **1,000 mg of curcumin per day** improves arthritis symptoms with an effect size comparable to some non-steroidal anti-inflammatories (like ibuprofen or diclofenac) over 8–12 weeks — but with fewer gastrointestinal side effects. More recent knee OA trials broadly agree.

The catch: curcumin on its own is poorly absorbed. You need one of these:

- **Curcumin + piperine** (black pepper extract) — the classic pairing, increases absorption dramatically.
- **Phytosome / liposomal / Meriva / Longvida** formulations — engineered for better uptake.

A teaspoon of turmeric powder in your dhal is lovely, but it won't reach the doses used in trials. That is a supplement conversation.

Head-to-head: ginger vs turmeric

Factor	Ginger	Turmeric (curcumin)
Strength of evidence for arthritis	Moderate	Moderate to strong
Typical study dose	500–1,000 mg/day extract	~1,000 mg/day curcumin
Compared to ibuprofen	Weaker	Similar in several trials
Absorption issues	Minimal	Significant — needs piperine or a phytosome
Cost of a food dose	Very low	Very low (but food doses are sub-therapeutic)
Also helps	Nausea, morning stiffness	Systemic inflammation, gut lining

Is turmeric better than ginger for arthritis?

For pain and function in knee osteoarthritis specifically, **turmeric** (as a properly absorbed curcumin supplement) has the stronger evidence base. Ginger is a good adjunct — and a better choice if you also struggle with nausea, IBS-type gut symptoms, or morning stiffness — but if I could only add one thing to a patient's routine, it would usually be a piperine-formulated curcumin at 500–1,000 mg/day.

Can I take ginger and turmeric together?

Yes — and it's what most trials of "arthritis blends" actually test. They work on overlapping pathways rather than the same receptor, so combining them is reasonable, not redundant. Just don't stack multiple high-dose supplements without telling your GP or pharmacist,

especially if you're on other medication.

How long before ginger or turmeric works?

Give either **at least 4 weeks, ideally 8–12**, at a consistent daily dose. Skipping days makes it very hard to tell whether it's helping. Track your pain honestly — a simple 0–10 score in the morning and evening for a fortnight before you start is worth its weight in gold.

Safety flags — read this before you buy anything

Both are safe for most adults, but there are real interactions:

- **Blood thinners** (warfarin, DOACs like apixaban, or high-dose aspirin) — both ginger and curcumin have mild antiplatelet effects. Check with your GP before starting.
- **Diabetes medication** — both can nudge blood glucose down; monitor if you're on insulin or sulphonylureas.
- **Gallstones or bile-duct disease** — turmeric stimulates bile flow and can trigger pain. Avoid high-dose curcumin.
- **Pregnancy** — culinary amounts are fine; supplement doses of curcumin are not recommended.
- **Rare liver injury** — a small number of case reports link high-dose curcumin (usually with piperine or phytosome formulations) to reversible hepatitis. Stop and see your GP if you develop jaundice, dark urine, or right-sided abdominal pain.

If you're on **methotrexate, biologics, or long-term NSAIDs**, treat these as add-ons, not replacements, and tell your rheumatology team.

How to actually eat more of both

You don't have to choose between capsules and cooking — most patients I see do both.

- **Golden milk:** 1 tsp turmeric + a pinch of black pepper + grated fresh ginger, simmered in warm milk (dairy or plant-based) with a little honey.
- **Anti-inflammatory smoothie:** frozen berries, banana, a thumb of fresh ginger, ½ tsp turmeric, black pepper, oat milk. See our [\[anti-inflammatory smoothie recipes\]](#)(/blog/anti-inflammatory-smoothie-recipes) for more.
- **Weeknight dhal or curry:** onion, garlic, fresh ginger, turmeric, black pepper — the Indian home kitchen has been doing this bioavailability trick for centuries.

- **Sheet-pan dinners:** grated ginger + turmeric + olive oil + lemon over salmon and vegetables.

If you want the bigger picture, our [\[Mediterranean diet 14-day plan for arthritis\]](/blog/mediterranean-diet-arthritis-14-day-plan) is where I'd start most patients before adding supplements.

The bottom line

- **Turmeric (curcumin, properly absorbed) has the stronger evidence** for reducing arthritis pain and stiffness, at roughly 1,000 mg per day for 8–12 weeks.
- **Ginger is a genuine, well-tolerated adjunct** at 500–1,000 mg per day, particularly if you also want help with morning stiffness or nausea.
- Both are safe for most adults, but check with your GP if you're on blood thinners, diabetes medication, or have gallstones.
- Neither is a cure. They sit alongside — never instead of — weight management, exercise, and the medication your rheumatology team recommends.

For a deeper dive into each on its own, see [\[turmeric and curcumin for arthritis: the evidence\]](/blog/turmeric-curcumin-arthritis-evidence) and [\[ginger root as a natural anti-inflammatory\]](/blog/ginger-root-natural-anti-inflammatory).

This article is for general information and does not replace personal medical advice. If your joint pain is new, worsening, or waking you at night, please speak to your GP.

Read next

- [\[Turmeric and Curcumin: Evidence-Based Arthritis Relief\]](/blog/turmeric-curcumin-arthritis-evidence) — a deeper dive into curcumin dosing, absorption and the strongest trial evidence.
- [\[Ginger Root: A Natural Anti-Inflammatory Food\]](/blog/ginger-root-natural-anti-inflammatory) — how to use ginger day-to-day, including tea, food and supplement forms.
- [\[Mediterranean Diet for Arthritis: A 14-Day UK Meal Plan\]](/blog/mediterranean-diet-arthritis-14-day-plan) — the anti-inflammatory eating pattern most patients should start with before adding supplements.
- [\[Anti-Inflammatory Herbs and Spices for Arthritis\]](/blog/anti-inflammatory-herbs-spices-arthritis) — the wider evidence-based herb and spice list, beyond ginger and turmeric.

- [Anti-Inflammatory Smoothie Recipes for Joint Pain](/blog/anti-inflammatory-smoothie-recipes) — practical recipes that pair ginger and turmeric with berries and leafy greens.
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Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about ginger vs turmeric for arthritis: which actually works??

Short answer: For most people with arthritis, turmeric (as a properly absorbed curcumin supplement at around 1,000 mg/day for 8–12 weeks) has the stronger evidence for reducing pain and stiffness. Ginger at 500–1,000 mg/day is a well-tolerated adjunct, especially if you also have morning stiffness or nausea. Check with your GP before starting.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.